

DIGITAL TV WAR

IPTV vs DTH vs Cable TV

Digital cable TV and DTH have stabilised over a period of time but IPTV, being a fresh entrant, still has to prove its edge over the other two media of TV broadcasting

■ AMIT GOEL

Television has been around for more than three decades and is an integral part of our lives as we depend on it for entertainment and knowledge. Ever-evolving technology has led to exponential changes in the world of television. The advent of digital TV rendered people the option of selecting the medium of their choice for television viewing. Every

one is going beyond terrestrial broadcast to get the best television viewing experience.

There are three kinds of digital TV broadcast systems existing today, which include satellite TV, digital cable TV and Internet protocol television (IPTV).

IPTV: New entrant

IPTV, being the latest arrival in the TV domain, may represent a threat

to the other two modes of television viewing. In IPTV, regular television channels are viewed through IP. Similar to satellite and cable TV, the signal is encrypted using vendor-specific security mechanisms and can only be decrypted by a receiver (set-top box or STB). The video is sent in the form of IP packets over the existing broadband infrastructure and assembled at the viewers' end with the help of an STB.

Existing broadband distribution infrastructure can be used for delivering TV signals, enabling the user to enjoy TV viewing over the same broadband connection as used for surfing the Internet.

This is beneficial for broadcasters as they can offer the 'triple play' service of voice, data and TV over the same network, using the same infrastructure. The 'triple play' service refers to the three different services of VoIP, Internet and IPTV bundled together and offered over the same network. With IPTV, one can be assured of better video quality and stereophonic sound, much like in the case of DTH and digital cable TV. Even the customer-specific services of video on demand (VOD) become a reality. Also, this allows broadcasters to have two-way communication with viewers—an advantage lacking in DTH and cable TV.

However, IPTV, still being in its stage of infancy, is not well established yet. Due to high bandwidth requirement (approximately 5 Gbps, even ADSL2+ technology can support only

